

Back to strictness?
Topics in Language and Mind
3 October 2017

1. The case of ‘every’

A standard picture: ‘every’ is context-sensitive; the contribution of context may be represented by a property D, the ‘domain restrictor’. ‘Every NP VP’ is true in a context where the domain restrictor is D iff there is nothing that has D and the property expressed by the NP while lacking the property expressed by the VP.

Predictions: the following argument-schemes are valid in the sense that they preserve truth when the context (including the interpretation of ‘every’):

‘Antecedent strengthening’: Every F is a G $\vdash$ Every F which is H is a G

‘Transitivity’: Every F is a G, Every G is a H $\vdash$ Every F is a H

‘Contraposition’: Every F is a G $\vdash$ Every non-G is a non-F

Counterexamples?

? Every philosopher went to the Dean’s reception $\vdash$ Every philosopher at the University of Hong Kong went to the Dean’s reception

? Every philosopher went to the Dean’s reception, Everyone with an office in Building 9 in the University of Hong Kong is a philosopher $\vdash$ Everyone with an office in Building 9 in the University of Hong Kong went to the Dean’s reception

? Every student who read that book didn’t read it carefully $\nvdash$ Every student who read that book carefully didn’t read that book

A standard response: these are not counterexamples: on the interpretations on which they might appear to be counterexamples, the context—in particular, the interpretation of ‘Every’—is not being held fixed.

Challenge: explain why context tends to change like this

2. Presupposition and how it helps

Basic idea: in addition to their main (assertive) role, some sentences also signal that certain things are *to be taken for granted*. When a sentence carries a presupposition, its negation, and the corresponding yes/no question carry the same presupposition.

John stopped smoking / John didn’t stop smoking / Did John stop smoking?

$\rightarrow$ John used to smoke

Mary realised she was speeding / Mary didn't realise she was speeding / Did Mary realise she was speeding

→ Mary was speeding

I met my daughter / I didn't meet my daughter / Did I meet my daughter?

→ I have a daughter

More controversially:

Every F is a G / Not every F is a G / Is every F a G?

→ Something is an F

If it were that P it would be that Q / It is not the case that if it were that P it would be that Q / If it were that P would it be that Q?

→ It might have been that P

(= Some P-world is accessible [from the actual world])

If P, Q / It is not the case that if P, Q / If P, Q?

→ It might be that P

Idea: presuppositions help us fix the interpretations of context-sensitive expressions. When someone utters a sentence that carries a presupposition, we look for an interpretation on which the presupposition is really obvious enough to be *properly* taken for granted. This often trumps the pressure to interpret repeated occurrences of the same word uniformly across a discourse.

3. Aside: a contrast between domain expansion and domain contraction

The presupposition effect often creates pressure for domains to *expand* over the course of a discourse. Getting them to *contract* is harder.

Every philosopher was at the meeting. We discussed the fact that some philosophers in Hong Kong will be visiting next month.

At the meeting, we discussed the fact that some philosophers in Hong Kong will be visiting next month. ? Every philosopher was there.

4. A warning about the truth-value-gap theory of presupposition

5. Dynamic meanings and the role of similarity

Von Stechow's further idea: the process of adjustment of the accessibility parameter is "automated". If the currently operative accessibility relation is such that some worlds don't see any P-worlds, and someone utters 'If it were that P, it would be the case that Q', the

current accessibility relation will expand just enough such that every world sees the most similar P-worlds to it, and all worlds at least as similar to it as they are.

- Note that this kind of mechanical evolution would not be plausible for ‘every’. Is it well-motivated for ‘if’?

Von Fintel’s technical implementation of the further idea:

There are things called ‘contexts’, which we can treat (simplifying) as pairs of an accessibility relation and a closeness relation. In addition to having truth conditions $\llbracket \phi \rrbracket_{f, \leq}$ relative to every context, a sentence also has a dynamic meaning $\mid \phi \mid_{\leq}$ relative to a closeness relation $\leq$, which is a function from accessibility relations to accessibility relations.

$\phi > \psi$ is ‘true in’ a context $\langle f, \leq \rangle$ at w iff all the ϕ -worlds in $\mid \phi > \psi \mid_{\leq}(f)$ are ψ -worlds.